establish a four-power concert of democracies with India, the United States, and Australia that might act as a counterweight to China in the Indo-Pacific.[35] Although India has been reluctant to formalise a pact of this nature, it has steadily augmented its bilateral partnerships with each of the countries in the putative Quad, thus achieving many of the security and economic benefits of such an arrangement without incurring the obvious cost of antagonising Beijing. In this manner, India has walked a fine line of coordinating with Japan on a number of issues relevant to the Indo-Pacific while also taking care to not overstep its boundaries with regard to China. For example, while India has been vocal on the need for a rules-based order in the region and the need for the peaceful resolution of maritime disputes in the South and East China Seas, New Delhi has stayed clear of official involvement in any of the disputes even as a mediator. India has similarly avoided addressing the North Korean nuclear challenge, going so far as to host the DPRK's foreign minister in New Delhi in April 2015.[36] Although recent official statements suggest that India's position on North Korea may be changing,[37] this is further evidence of a flexible and pragmatic Indian strategy that is as open to aligning with Japanese interests on specific issues at specific times as it is wary of getting embroiled in unnecessary conflicts well beyond its regional sphere of interest.

India's main objective in the Indo-Pacific lies in ensuring that China's growing ambition and footprint do not unduly impinge on India's own priorities and relationships in South Asia and beyond. Naturally, this objective also includes managing India's ongoing bilateral border conflict with China, as in the case of the Doklam crisis of mid-2017.[38] To New Delhi's pleasant surprise, while other major powers, including the United States, remained silent during the standoff, Japan publicly supported India's position – with Ambassador Kenji Hiramatsu stating that Japan understood